attract influential companies from the West, which then played an important role in obtaining for China a permanent Most Favoured Nation (MFN) status from the US instead of an annual clearance. Before the grant of MFN status to China, the US gave an annual waiver to China from various trade-related barriers and tariffs applied by the US to non-market economies. As an MFN economy, China would enjoy the same trade privileges that the US extended to other trade partners. Later, these US multinational companies also lobbied for China to be admitted to the WTO, which greatly helped China to integrate itself into an expanding global economy and gain access to the large consumer markets of the US, Europe and Japan. Ironically, President Clinton justified US support for China's membership of the WTO on the grounds that increasing prosperity and access to the internet would inevitably lead the country towards liberal democracy. He said that trying to control the internet would be 'like nailing Jello to the wall'.[1] Yet China has been able to establish strict controls over its digital economy, using the very tools that enable swift transmission of information to create a surveillance state. Internet-based platforms like Google, Facebook and Twitter are not available in China. This has allowed home-grown variants like Weibo to flourish, but subject to strict monitoring and censorship by the state. Clinton could not have been more wrong.

During the Clinton years, China faced a major security challenge. In order to influence elections in Taiwan and forestall the victory of the pro-independence Democratic Progressive Party in 1996, China launched a number of missiles in and around the island, hoping to intimidate voters into rejecting the pro-independence candidates. Clinton responded by dispatching the US Seventh Fleet into the Taiwan Strait, which compelled the Chinese to stop the missile firings. This led China to focus on developing and deploying new capabilities, such as a new class of anti-ship missiles that could threaten US aircraft carrier groups and a large fleet of submarines with missile capabilities, again in order to deny superior US naval forces access to China's near seas. This Anti-Access/ Area Denial strategy has been successful to the extent that the US has not been able to prevent China from occupying several islands in the South China Sea and